HYBRID PARTICIPATION INNOVATION LAB · ARTICLE 2

Social and digital vulnerabilities: the role of participatory processes in the reconfiguration of urban and digital space

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Mahsa Shahi · Kuhyar Saeedi · Farida Safdari · Gelila Tsehaye Melesse · Md Nazmul Islam · Pranto Argha Sarker

THE PAPER AT A GLANCE

Can participation include the most vulnerable, or only legitimise decisions?

Research question

How do organisations regenerating peripheral areas see their role, limits and chances inside the "neoliberal city"?

Where

Six cases in Rome, Naples, Milan, Turin, Florence and Reggio Calabria: two each in the North, Centre and South.

Method

Qualitative case studies: background research, then semi-structured interviews with each organisation (March–May 2022).

Core argument

Without real participation by people who live there, urban regeneration stays "on paper", and participation becomes a mere procedure.

KEY CONCEPT 1

The risk: participation as decoration

Neoliberal city

Efficiency, competition and "governance" replace political debate. Citizens become users of services, not makers of the agenda.

"Participationism"

Procedures that give **access** but no real power: they legitimise choices already made at the top.

Two side effects

The commons risk being privatised, and facilitators risk becoming a "technocracy" of participation.

THE TEST THEY PROPOSE

Is inclusion just **access**, or is participation **meaningful**? Do citizens receive services, or help build the public agenda?

KEY CONCEPT 2

Liminal spaces and digital capital

Liminal space

A space "at the boundary of two dominant spaces, which is not fully part of either" (Dale and Burrell, 2008): not clearly owned, shaped by marginalisation and gentrification.

When communities make it meaningful, it becomes a place of dwelling, not an empty edge.

Digital capital

Skills plus technology (Ragnedda). Like any capital, it accumulates unequally and reproduces inequality.

The most vulnerable have the least, and datafication and platforms widen the gap.

SIX CASE STUDIES

Very different organisations, same periphery problem

City	Organisation	Type	Focus	Institutional	Social capital
Milan	Cariplo Foundation	Philanthropic foundation	Regeneration of 3 areas	High	Medium
Florence	Lama	Social enterprise	Temporary use of spaces	High	Medium
Turin	IoVivoIn	Civic community media	Networking 2 districts	Low	High
Rome	Alberi in Periferia	Volunteer NPO	Planting trees in suburbs	Low	Medium
Naples	GRIDAS (Scampia)	Cultural association	Art, carnival, environment	Medium	High
Reggio Calabria	Macramé	Consortium of social co-ops	Community development	Medium	High

FINDINGS

What the six cases show

Institutions: bureaucratic or absent

They rarely join bottom-up processes. All organisations say results would come faster if institutions took a non-bureaucratic and more directive approach.

Social capital is the engine

Committees, schools, associations and trusted networks open doors in places even the police could not enter.

Money shapes participation

Private funds bring an income logic; where third-sector resources lead, "creative participation" is stronger.

The pandemic went digital

Online events, digital communities and community media kept ties alive and created new formats.

THE PAPER'S MODEL · TABLE 3

Two ways in, two depths of participation

	INCLUSIVE	MEANINGFUL
By invitation Top-down	**Consultation, collaborative governance**	**Deliberative processes**
Breaking in Bottom-up, conflict	**Advanced collaborative governance**	**Co-management of territory, direct social action**

OUR CRITICAL READING

A sharp lens, but the residents' voice is missing

Strengths

Strong theory: separates access from real influence.

Italy-wide: North, Centre and South, very different actors.

Brings in digital inequality as part of vulnerability.

Limits

Only organisations interviewed: vulnerable residents speak through others.

Self-assessment: impacts are as reported by the organisations themselves.

Dense theory, lighter on practical design advice.

WHAT WE TAKE FOR OUR PROJECT

Tor Bella Monaca is in this paper

Our site is liminal

An interviewee compares Arghillà to Scampia and Tor Bella Monaca: hard to enter, closed by a security-only response.

Design for low digital capital

The AI assistant must work without an app too: paper, phone, a person.

Enter through social capital

Tenant committees, unions, charities and the parish: the "trusted bridges" of our Step 2 map.

Avoid participationism

Tenants must decide the fairness rule, not just approve one already written.

FOR DISCUSSION

Questions for the class

1. How can we tell real participation from "participationism" in a project we design ourselves?

2. Can digital tools build digital capital, or do they always favour those who already have it?

3. Should institutions lead participation in peripheries, or step back and support bottom-up groups?